

◀ SCIENTIFIC PROGRESS

Dutch scientists made groundbreaking scientific discoveries and inventions in the 17th century. In 1608, Hans Lippershey invented the first telescope, and in the 1670s Antonie van Leeuwenhoek became the first person to study microscopic life using an advanced microscope he'd designed (left).



Zig-zag shaped
outer canal

RINGS OF CANALS ▶

Now the Dutch capital, Amsterdam was the leading city of the Dutch Republic. As it grew in the 17th century, three major canals were dug in rings around the medieval center (shown on this map partway through construction). Overlooking them, fine townhouses were built for the city's wealthiest inhabitants to live in.



DUTCH INDEPENDENCE

1568

The 17 provinces of the Spanish Netherlands rise in rebellion against their Spanish Catholic rulers, starting the Eighty Years' War for independence.

1581

Seven northern Dutch provinces—all Protestant—formally announce their independence from Spain.

1588

The United Provinces of the Netherlands—the Dutch Republic—is established as a federal republic (a union of states joined together under an elected government).

1648

The Dutch Republic is recognized as an independent country by the Peace of Münster, a treaty signed between the Netherlands and Spain.

1672

The Dutch Republic has to fight for its independence when it finds itself at war against France and Britain—a period known as the *Rampjaar* (Disaster Year).



Red and white "broken tulips" were the most valuable during "Tulip Mania."

◀ TULIP MANIA

As new and rare objects were introduced to Dutch society, they were traded on the stock market. In the 1630s, an obsession with trading tulip bulbs—then an exotic new import from Turkey—gripped Amsterdam's middle classes, increasing their price sharply. Some people even sold their homes to buy bulbs. Then, in 1637, the price of tulip bulbs suddenly crashed, and many of those who had got involved lost a fortune. It was the first stock market crash.

▼ STOCK EXCHANGE

The economic system known as capitalism first emerged in the Netherlands in the early 1600s. The world's first central bank was set up in Amsterdam in 1609, and the first stock exchange (below) was built in the city in 1611. It was a place for traders to buy and sell stocks (shares of ownership) in the newly created trading companies.

